that pulled Israel away from its true path. “Liberal”, then, has acquired a particular meaning in the Israeli-Palestinian context, a way to mark oneself out as a critic of the occupation, a supporter of both Palestinian self-determination and a return to this idyllic *status quo ante*. For the liberal Zionists, this is Israel’s most pressing concern. It needs to end “the conflict” in order to save its identity—its very soul, as Roger Cohen wrote—and arrest the rightward shift.

A compelling argument, simple and elegant. But it is also based on three major misconceptions.

First, the idealized past was hardly ideal, at least for Israelis outside of the secular Ashkenazi elite. Mizrahi and Sephardic Jews were subject to widespread discrimination. The founder of the state, David Ben-Gurion, once described them as having “[not] a trace of Jewish or human education.” The ultra-Orthodox, too, were seen as backwards, in need of “secularizing”. The early Zionists granted them a number of concessions, like an exemption from army service, because they believed the *haredim* to be a vestige of exile, one that would quickly disappear. The Palestinian minority lived under martial law for nearly two decades. Israel was ruled by left-wing Labor governments that were hardly less militaristic than today’s Likud-led coalition. It was a Labor government that blessed the first Israeli settlements.

The other two misconceptions are deeply intertwined. One is the belief that the alarming trends in Israeli society are blips, aberrations that can be easily undone. The other is the assumption that they are a pressing concern for many Israelis, like they are for many American Jews. Yet the problems that alarm the “liberal Zionist” intelligentsia—the settler movement, growing nationalism and religiosity, racism, efforts to undermine democracy—are features, not bugs. They are either the results of conscious government decisions, some of which were taken by “good” Labor leaders, or they are inevitable outgrowths of Zionism itself. Nor do they provoke the same level of concern inside Israel, where the public is increasingly right-wing, hawkish, and focused on socioeconomic problems.

Israel is not an outpost of the Jewish diaspora on the Mediterranean. The belief that it is says more about the state of Western Jewry than it does about Israel. Nor is it a Western-style democracy that made a single bad choice in 1967. It is something else entirely, and to believe otherwise is unhelpful: for Israelis, who must wake up to the very real battle over their